

PLATFORM BRIEF — 4 PAGES

How it works

Customer · Operator · Sunspot HQ · 24 May 2026

What Sunspot is, in one paragraph

Sunspot is a marketplace for Maltese beach venues. Customers reserve the exact sunbed, cabana or VIP gazebo they want, pay through us, and present a QR code at the gate. Operators get bookings on their phone, accept or decline, and receive weekly bank payouts. Sunspot takes 8% of each transaction; the operator keeps the other 92% with no listing fees, no monthly minimums, no exclusivity. Built in Valletta. 112 venues across Malta, Gozo and Comino at launch.

Three audiences, three surfaces

Each audience has a different surface. They share the same data backbone.

Audience	Surface	What they do
Customer	sunspot.mt (public site)	Browse, pick a spot, pay, get a QR
Operator	sunspot.mt/operator/ (PWA)	Accept bookings, scan QR, manage layout
Sunspot HQ + power operator	WordPress admin	Onboard venues, override actions, edit content

The customer flow

From landing page to checked-in, end to end.

1	Land on sunspot.mt. Live header strip shows how many sunbeds are bookable right now, the sea temperature, and tonight's sunset time.
2	Browse 112 venues by region (Sliema, Gozo, Comino...) or category (beach club, lido, rooftop, floating). The Map toggle plots them all on Malta with click-through.
3	Tap a venue → full detail page with photos, hours, amenities, location.
4	Reserve opens the booking page with the live blueprint of the venue. Tap the exact sunbed, cabana or VIP gazebo — each is colour-coded and price-tagged.
5	Pick a date + guest count , see the live total update as you add or remove spots.
6	Checkout — name, email, phone, card (or Apple/Google Pay). Stripe handles payment, with a 10-minute hold so nobody else can grab the spot while you finish.
7	Confirmation page shows a branded receipt ticket with the venue, your spots, the QR code and the booking reference (BJ-1234-XY format).
8	Day-of — show the QR at the gate. Operator scans it and your status flips to 'arrived'. Free cancellation up to 24 hours before.
9	My bookings — every reservation in one place, status updates live (Pending → Confirmed by venue → Checked in) without refreshing.

The operator flow

Operators install the PWA from sunspot.mt/operator/ — adds to home screen like a real app.

1	Onboard: Sunspot HQ creates the venue in WordPress, assigns the operator as the author of that post. Operator gets a temporary password.
2	First sign-in — operator picks their venue from a card-based switcher (they only ever see their own venues; never competitors').
3	Set up the layout in the Layout tab — one-click templates for Pool club / Beach club / Rooftop / Lido give them a full venue in seconds. Drag to fine-tune, add or remove spots, set per-spot prices.
4	Connect Stripe (one-time KYC via Stripe Connect Express) — sets up weekly bank payouts to the operator's IBAN.
5	Wake up to bookings on the Today tab. The live hero shows occupied / pending arrivals / checked in. Activity feed: 'Lara M. checked in to A12 · 2 min ago'.
6	Accept or decline each booking with one tap. Customer is notified by email and live in their My bookings page. Declined bookings auto-refund and free the spot.
7	Walk-ins via the floating + button — staff captures a cash-paying guest in 5 seconds.
8	Gate scan — tap Scan in the bottom nav, point the phone camera at the QR, status flips to 'arrived' instantly.
9	Stats tab — weekly bookings, revenue, payout amount, top booking days.
10	Sunday midnight — Stripe auto-payout. 92% to the operator's IBAN, 8% to Sunspot. Operator sees it in the Stats tab on Monday.

The Sunspot HQ flow

What we do day-to-day in WordPress admin. The 'power operator' subset is what we give to operators who outgrow the PWA and need bulk tools.

1	Onboard a new operator: WP admin → Users → Add new → role Venue Operator. Send them their app password.
2	Create their venue post → set photos, hours, amenities, location, sunbed prices. Assign them as the post author so they're scoped to that venue server-side.
3	Bulk-import when listing many venues at once via the CSV importer.
4	Monitor the booking queue across all venues (admin sees everything; operators only see their own).
5	Override when an operator can't (manual refund, force-cancel, swap a booking to a different venue).
6	Edit content — Field Guide articles, FAQ entries, partner experiences, all CPTs in WP.
7	Weekly — Stripe payouts run automatically; we check the Stats dashboard for anomalies (unusual cancellation rate, stuck holds, etc.).

Trust, safety, and what makes us different

Double-booking is physically impossible

Custom MySQL table **wp_sunspot_holds** with a UNIQUE constraint on (venue, spot, date, status). Even if two browsers race for the same sunbed, the second INSERT throws a duplicate-key error and that customer sees "this spot was just taken". No race condition is possible at the database layer.

Operators only see their own venues

Every operator REST endpoint is gated by capability check + own-venue scope via **sunspot_my_venue_slugs()**. Even with a valid JWT, an operator cannot read another operator's bookings, layout, or stats. Verified server-side; not a UI illusion.

Idempotent Stripe webhook

Stripe occasionally re-delivers webhook events. We track the last 500 event IDs and short-circuit replays. Belt-and-braces lookup by **_stripe_pi** ensures we never create a duplicate booking even if both safeguards fail.

Editorial integrity

Sponsored guide articles are labelled at the top, not hidden in a footnote. Featured placements don't buy positive reviews — we've turned down sponsorships for venues we wouldn't recommend. All published rates are on the public rate card.

Generated 24 May 2026. Source: [bin/how_it_works_pdf.py](#). For questions about anything in this brief, mark@sunspot.mt.